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How Russian attacks, European protectionism and drought are trapping Ukraine's vital grain

By Bartosz Brzeziński · Aug 12, 2026, 7:32 PM · [View in your browser](#)

Ukraine's normally copious grain exports are stuck in the country — caught between Russian attacks in the Black Sea, drought on the Danube and distrust among Kyiv's closest allies.

It's bad news for global food prices.

"If it keeps going like this, you'll have once again a global price increase of at least 25, 30 percent, with all the consequences we had in 2022 for world food inflation," Ukraine's Agriculture Minister Taras Vysotskyi told POLITICO.

With missile strikes keeping cargo ships away from its ports, Kyiv is scrambling, yet again for a way out via Europe. But its fallback routes run overland through EU countries, including Poland, Hungary and Slovakia, where previous waves of Ukrainian grain left governments facing a fierce domestic backlash.

The last surge of Ukrainian agricultural exports through Eastern Europe unleashed mass protests from farmers, particularly in Poland, who complained that cheap Ukrainian produce that was meant to merely pass through the region was instead ending up on their domestic markets. Poland imposed a ban on Ukrainian grain in 2023, alongside similar measures in Hungary and Slovakia, defying EU trade rules and souring relations with Ukraine.

Kyiv's fresh pleas — and insistence that the grain would only transit through its EU neighbors — have prompted Warsaw to reassure its own farmers that none of it will end up in Poland.

"We are doing everything to keep the embargo," Polish Agriculture Minister Stefan Krajewski told Radio ZET on Monday, referring to Poland's ban on Ukrainian grain imports.

Blocked bounty

One of the world's largest grain producers, Ukraine typically sends more than 90 percent of its agricultural exports by sea. The disruption of that trade after Russia's 2022 invasion helped drive global food prices to record highs. This summer, Russia and Ukraine have intensified attacks on each other's ports and shipping across the Black Sea.

Ukraine exported just 463,000 metric tons of grain in the first nine days of August — about one-third of the usual pace, said Vysotskyi. By November, when the new harvest comes in, the country risks running out of storage for grain it cannot export.

Kyiv asked the European Commission for €220 million last week to help its farmers weather the disruption.

The non-repayable grant would subsidize bank loans, allowing small- and medium-sized farms to hold on to their grain until shipping resumes rather than sell at a loss. A Commission spokesperson confirmed receiving the request but did not say whether Brussels would provide the money.

But money can only buy time. The bigger problem is getting ships back into Ukraine's ports.

No grain vessel has entered the ports around Odesa since late July, even though they remain open. That month, a Russian missile struck a corn carrier leaving port, killing 10 people aboard. The vessel sank a week later.

Since the attack, crews have refused to sail and shipping companies have suspended service.

"Ship owners and crews are just afraid. They are not ready to send the ships at all," said Vysotskyi. "It's not that it's impossible to make it. They are just not ready to."

Back to the border

With the Black Sea route stalled, Ukraine is negotiating with Romania, Poland, Hungary, Slovakia and Moldova to move more grain overland.

But those routes cannot simply replace maritime exports.

Moving grain by rail and road costs \$50 to \$70 more per ton, said Vysotskyi. When grain prices soared after Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022, exporters could absorb that premium. At today's prices, they cannot.

"It's nonprofitable," said Vysotskyi.

Ukraine's main alternative route, through Romania, is also running into constraints. Low water levels on the Danube are limiting the amount of cargo that can reach the Black Sea port of Constanța.

And moving more grain overland revives another problem for Kyiv: the political backlash in its EU neighbors.

Polish farmers blockaded crossings with Ukraine in 2023 and 2024, turning agricultural trade into one of the most politically explosive issues between Kyiv and one of its strongest wartime supporters.

But Ukraine, said Vysotskyi, is not asking for greater access to the EU market.

EU quotas now cap Ukrainian wheat sales to the bloc at 1.3 million tons a year which, according to Vysotskyi, makes a repeat of the earlier influx "legally impossible." Kyiv would seek a larger quota only if the EU itself proposed one, he added.

"There should be consensus inside the EU, with EU farmers," he said.

Warsaw has been adamant that its grain embargo will stay. But while Ukrainian grain can't be sold in Poland, the government has been working with Kyiv to help pass it through.

Talks with Kyiv “concern exclusively the smooth transport of Ukrainian grain to third countries, not its export or admission to the Polish market,” said Polish Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Maciej Wewiór, adding that Ukrainian grain remains critical for many countries in Asia and Africa.

Trust deficit

For Polish farmers, assurances that the grain will pass through the country uninterrupted are not enough, with farm groups arguing that some shipments supposedly bound for other countries never actually leave Poland.

Gustaw Jędrejek, head of the Lublin Chamber of Agriculture and one of the leaders of the border blockades, alleged that shipments are recorded electronically as delivered abroad while the grain itself is sold inside Poland.

“Documents travel to Lithuania, the Czech Republic or Slovakia — and the grain stays in Poland,” he said. The Polish government has consistently denied such allegations.

Asked whether he trusted assurances that additional Ukrainian grain would simply pass through the country, Jędrejek was unequivocal.

“I absolutely don’t believe it.”

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